

## 3.4.1 Strategies for understanding

### 3.4.1.1 Ignoring words which are not needed

Many tasks contain words which are not essential for an understanding of the main points of the text. What is important in the text is often presented more than once, in different ways: the student may not understand a point in one form of words and understand it fully in another.

### 3.4.1.2 Using the visual and verbal context

The skilled reader can find many clues about the purpose and content of a text from a study of the layout, the title, the length, the typeface and any related pictures.

When reading and listening, students can learn to infer the meaning of new words from the verbal context. For example, someone who did not know the word *chêne* might be able, after some appropriate practice, to deduce from the following context that it is some sort of tree: // *s'est assis sous un chêne: dans ses branches, un oiseau chantait.*

### 3.4.1.3 Making use of grammatical markers and categories

Students will be helped to master all these strategies if, when reading and listening, they learn to use such clues as the plural forms of nouns and verbs, the way verbs change to form tenses, word order and other such features to help them recognise to which category (verb, noun, adjective etc) an unknown word belongs. This can be a considerable help in making intelligent guesses about the meaning of the word.

### 3.4.1.4 Making use of the social and cultural context

Another aid to the drawing of correct inferences is for the students to bear in mind that there are regularities in the real world which make it possible to anticipate what people may say or write about it. The ability to predict occurrences in the real world makes it possible to anticipate words, and their meaning, in a given context. This is one reason why it is important for a French course to develop awareness and understanding of countries and communities where French is spoken.

### 3.4.1.5 Using common patterns with French

Knowledge of the following patterns of word formation in French can help to understand a text.

- *re* prefix (eg *commencer* – *recommencer*, *faire* – *refaire*)
- the *eur* ending applied to verbs (eg *employer* – *employeur*) and applied to adjectives (eg *grand*, *grandeur*, etc)
- *ette* ending (eg *maison* – *maisonnette*; *tarte* – *tartelette*; *camion* – *camionnette*)
- *able* ending (eg *laver* – *lavable*; *manger* – *mangeable*)
- *aine* ending (eg *quinze* – *quinzaine*; *cent* – *centaine*; *douze* – *douzaine*)
- *té* ending (eg *bon* – *bonté*; *beau* – *beauté*)
- *ier* ending (eg *épicerie* – *épicier*; *police* – *policier*; *ferme* – *fermier*)
- *in* prefix (eg *actif* – *inactif*; *connu* – *inconnu*; *cassable* – *incassable*)
- *ion* and *ation* endings (eg *réparer* – *réparation*; *inventer* – *invention*).

### 3.4.1.6 Using cognates and near-cognates

A few 'false friends' (eg *expérimenté*, *sensible*, *large*) make it necessary to use this strategy with care and in collaboration with the strategy of using the visual and verbal context above. However, for each 'false friend' there are very many 'good friends' of which anglophone learners of French can make good use. These fall into two main categories: cognates and near-cognates.

## Cognates

There are many words which have the same form and essentially the same meaning in French and in English (eg *innocent, justice, muscle, rectangle*). When such words occur in context, students can be expected to understand them in English and French.

## Near-cognates

Students will be expected to understand words which meet the criteria above but which differ slightly in their written form in French, usually by the addition of one or more accents and/or the repetition of a letter (eg *création, hygiène, mâle, littérature*).

### 3.4.1.7 Using common patterns between French and English

There are thousands of words in French which, although not having exactly the same form as the English word, can easily be understood with the application of a few, simple rules. When words which can be understood using the rules below occur in context, students will be expected to understand them.

| Rule                                                                         | Examples                                              |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| The French word adds an 'e'                                                  | <i>branche, liquide, signe, vaste</i>                 |
| The English word adds an 'e'                                                 | <i>futur, masculin, paradis, pur</i>                  |
| Words which end with 'e' or 'é' in French and with 'y' in English            | <i>beauté, liberté, mystère, armée</i>                |
| Words which end with 'i' or 'ie' in French and with 'y' in English           | <i>économie, parti, tragédie</i>                      |
| Words which end with <i>aire</i> in French and with 'ar' or 'ary' in English | <i>grammaire, militaire, populaire</i>                |
| Words which end with <i>el</i> in French and with <i>al</i> in English       | <i>individuel, officiel</i>                           |
| French adverbs ending with <i>ment</i> which end with 'ly' in English        | <i>complètement, généralement, spécialement</i>       |
| Verbs which add 'r' or 'er' in the infinitive in French                      | <i>admirer, confirmer, inspecter</i>                  |
| Verbs which end with <i>er</i> in French and with 'ate' in English           | <i>assassiner, cultiver, décorer</i>                  |
| Words where 'o' or 'u' in English is replaced by <i>ou</i> in French         | <i>approuver, gouvernement, mouvement, bouddhiste</i> |
| Words where a 'd' is added in English                                        | <i>aventure, avance, juge</i>                         |

| Rule                                                                                         | Examples                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Present participles ending in <i>ant</i> in French and 'ing' in English                      | <i>dégoûtant, commençant, nageant</i><br>Students will be expected to understand such present participles where the infinitive of the verb is a listed word |
| Words which end with <i>e</i> or <i>eux</i> in French and with 'ous' in English              | <i>énorme, précieux, religieux</i>                                                                                                                          |
| Words which end with <i>que</i> in French and with 'c', 'ck', 'ch', 'k', or 'cal' in English | <i>automatique, attaque, physique, risque</i>                                                                                                               |
| Words which end with <i>f</i> in French and with 've' in English                             | <i>actif, adjectif, possessif</i>                                                                                                                           |
| Words which end with <i>eur</i> in French and with 'our', 'or', or 'er' in English           | <i>boxeur, empereur, vigueur</i>                                                                                                                            |
| Words which end with <i>e</i> or <i>re</i> in French and with 'er' in English                | <i>ministre, ordre, interprète</i>                                                                                                                          |
| Words which end with <i>e</i> in French and 'a' in English                                   | <i>drame, propagande</i>                                                                                                                                    |
| Words where 'u' in English is replaced by <i>o</i> in French                                 | <i>fonction, prononciation</i>                                                                                                                              |
| Words where 'oun' in English is replaced by <i>on</i> in French                              | <i>annoncer, prononcer</i>                                                                                                                                  |
| Words which have a circumflex accent in French and an 's' in English                         | <i>forêt, honnête, intérêt, tempête</i>                                                                                                                     |
| Words where <i>dé</i> in French is replaced by 'dis' in English                              | <i>décourager, dégoûter</i>                                                                                                                                 |
| Words where <i>é</i> or <i>es</i> in French is replaced by 's' in English                    | <i>espace, éponge</i>                                                                                                                                       |

Strategies such as those outlined above will generally be more easily applied in reading than in listening, as reading offers more opportunities to slow down, look at unknown items at leisure and study the context. Words which **look** the same in two languages may **sound** quite different.

Also, in French, there are many sound features which are not word-based (eg elision; whether or not 'e' is sounded; stress; intonation) and so make the application of some of the strategies for understanding unknown words more difficult. In particular, it must be remembered that grammatical markers in the spoken language are often quite different from those in the written one. The most obvious are the plural forms:

- nouns and adjectives frequently have no plural forms: plurality is shown by a change in the pronunciation of the article or some other related word:

*le grand pont – les grands ponts;*

- Verbs either have no plural form at all:

*il donne/ils donnent: il chantait/ils chantaient*

- or add a consonant:

*il vend/ils vendent: il finit/ils finissent.*

To hear accurately, students should have the specific differences of the spoken language brought to their attention. However some of the general strategies for understanding listed above can be used successfully in listening. For example:

- ignoring words which are not needed for a successful completion of the task set
- using the (visual and) verbal context
- making use of the social and cultural context
- using common patterns within French.

In addition, the following strategies are included for listening and understanding (in place of reading the above strategies regarding cognates and common patterns between French and English).

### 3.4.1.8 Near-cognates

Strictly speaking there are no French words which sound exactly like their English equivalents. There are a few near-cognates which are relatively easily recognised. They are often words imported from other languages eg whisky, ski.

Some words which in reading cause no problem can be unrecognisable in speech. For example, *spécialisation* has seven distinct syllables in French and five in English, it has five specific pronunciation differences in French and a complete change of stress pattern.

However, provided that certain relationships between sound patterns in French and English are recognised, then French words with a clearly 'different' pronunciation in English can be understood. Examples of patterns where a communicative strategy can be applied include the following:

- the sound [i] will always involve a French *i*, which in English may be a diphthong eg pipe, mine
- the sound [a] will always involve a French *a* which in English may be a diphthong eg nation
- the termination [œr] is always *eur* which may be English -or or -er eg *acteur*
- the termination [sio] is always *-tion* or *-sion* and therefore English [Yen], eg nation, passion
- the termination [if] in French is *-if* and in English is often "-ive" eg *actif*
- the termination [ik] in French is *-ique* and *ic* and in English is often "-ic" or "-ical" eg *physique*
- the initial [Y] is usually the English ch eg *chapelle*, *charme*.
- the termination [mɑ̃] which can be added to many of the adjectives in the lists to form the adverb eg *complètement*
- the termination [ɑ̃] which can be added to the stem of listed verbs to give the present participle eg *mangeant*, *gémissant*.